

Topic 3.4 - Saying it so it lands

A real classroom situation

	Verbal	Non-verbal
Carries best	Precise content: definitions, instructions, reasoning	Stance: interest, impatience, whether you mean it
How it fails	Too much at once; words the pupil does not hold	Read wrongly, and read without you deciding to send it
How fast it is read	Word by word, in sequence	Immediately, and all at once
When they contradict each other	The class believes the non-verbal channel. Saying "take your time" while glancing at the clock teaches only the glance.	

Furlich (2016), N=77: the verbal measure was significant, the non-verbal one was not. One study in one setting, not a general law - and not a licence for the widely repeated claim that communication is 93 per cent non-verbal, which its own author never supported.

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Mr Tariq says, to a Class 7 that has just produced a very poor set of homework: "It is fine. We will go over it again. Nobody is in trouble."

While he says it he is standing behind his desk with his arms folded, he has not looked up from the pile of exercise books, and his voice has dropped at the end of each sentence. He then calls the register in a flat tone and moves on.

He has told them, in words, that they are safe. Almost none of them believe it, and for the rest of the lesson very few of them ask anything.

Explanation

Verbal communication in the classroom

Verbal communication is the words themselves: what is said, how it is structured and whether it can be followed by the person hearing it. In a classroom it does four distinct jobs, and teachers are usually much better at the first than the other three.

Explaining. Making an idea available. The common failures are vocabulary the class does not hold, and a sequence that makes sense to someone who already understands. A worked example before the rule usually beats the rule before the example, because the example gives the rule something to be about.

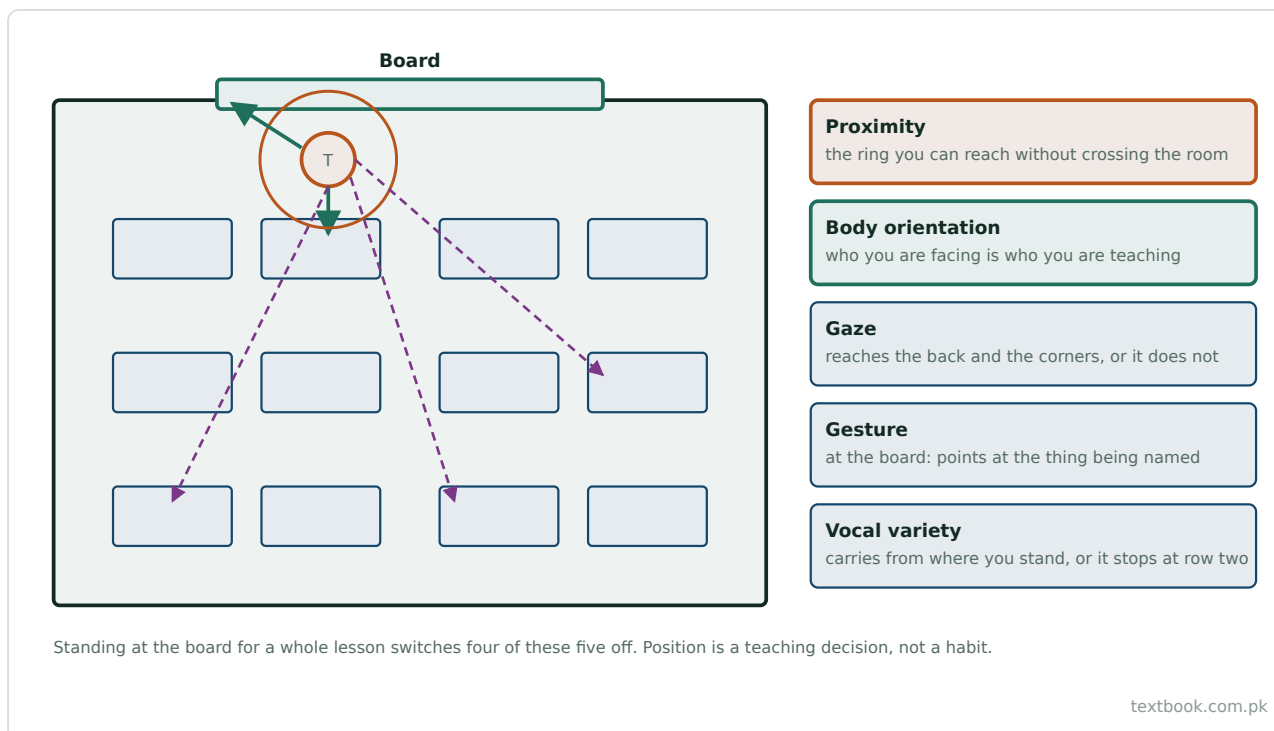
Instructing. Telling a class what to do. Instructions fail for mundane reasons: too many steps at once, given while pupils are already moving, or given in a form that cannot be checked. "Open your books, turn to page forty, answer the first three questions in your notebooks, and you have eight minutes" is four instructions and a time limit delivered in one breath. Half the room will have retained two of them.

Questioning. This is where verbal skill most separates teachers. A question either discovers what pupils think or confirms that somebody can say the right words. "Does everyone understand?" does neither; it samples confidence, not comprehension, and it systematically over-samples the pupils who are already fine. Asking a pupil to explain the step to a neighbour, or to say which of two wrong answers is closer and why, discovers something.

Responding. What a teacher says immediately after a pupil speaks. This is the single most consequential sentence in the exchange, because it teaches the rest of the class what happens to people who answer. A wrong answer met with "no, who else?" closes the room. The same wrong answer met with "what made you think that?" keeps it open and usually surfaces the misconception the whole class is holding.

Furlich (2016) found verbal immediacy behaviours, which include using pupils' names, inviting questions, and referring to shared classroom experience, associated with learner motivation. These are small verbal habits rather than a style, and they are learnable.

Non-verbal communication: its types and their classroom use



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Non-verbal communication is everything carried outside the words. Research on teacher non-verbal immediacy works with a fairly consistent set of channels, used across the immediacy studies this topic draws on, including eye contact, gesture, relaxed and directed body position, smiling, vocal expressiveness, movement and proximity. Keelson and colleagues (2024) measure a subset of these directly, reporting significant associations between facial expression and gesture and students' perceptions of teaching quality. The figure above places them in a room.

Proximity. Where you stand. Distance reads as detachment; moving among desks reads as availability and, incidentally, makes off-task behaviour visible without a word being said.

Body orientation. Which way you face. Facing the board while explaining sends the explanation to the board. Facing a pupil who is speaking tells the class that answering is worth the teacher's attention.

Gaze and eye contact. Who you look at, and how the looking is distributed. Most untrained teachers over-attend to one side of a room and to the front three rows, and the pupils in the neglected zone reliably disengage. This is measurable in a single lesson and easy to fix once seen.

Facial expression, including smiling. The channel pupils read fastest, and the one a teacher is least aware of moment to moment, which is why it so often reports a state the teacher did not intend to announce.

Gesture. Used well, gesture carries structure that words cannot: the shape of a graph, the sequence of three steps held on three fingers. Used absently, it is noise.

Vocal variety. Pace, pitch, volume and pause. This is the most under-used channel by trainees, who tend to a flat delivery under nerves. A pause before a key sentence does more work than repeating it.

A misconception about the whole list: *non-verbal communication is body language you can fake.* Some of it can be performed for a few minutes, which is why an observed lesson is an unreliable sample. Across a term it cannot, because the channels run continuously and you cannot attend to all of them while also teaching. What actually changes them is changing the underlying thing: a teacher who genuinely finds a pupil's wrong answer interesting does not have to remember to look up.

Abekah Keelson and colleagues (2024) found that learners' ratings of teaching quality were associated with a lecturer's facial expressions and gestures. That is the professional significance: the channel is not decoration, it is part of what is being judged.

Read the evidence with its scope attached. That study surveyed 614 university students in Ghana by self-report questionnaire. Furlich (2016) studied instructor immediacy and student motivation at a small liberal arts university, and found the **verbal** immediacy relationship with motivation significant while the **non-verbal** one was not. The published abstract gives neither a sample size nor a country, so treat both as unstated rather than small and American. Neither study was conducted in a school, in Pakistan, or with children. They are the best evidence available here and they are evidence about university lecturing. Treat the channels as worth attending to, and treat any precise claim about how much they matter to a Class 7 pupil as unestablished.

A misconception to discard, and a caution about its replacement. You may meet the claim that a fixed large percentage of communication, commonly 93%, is non-verbal. It comes from Mehrabian's 1967 experiments on how people

judge a speaker's *attitude* from single words and tone, and it does not support any general claim about classroom talk. Do not repeat it.

Now the caution, because it applies to this book as much as to anyone. The claim usually offered in its place, that **the non-verbal channel wins when the two channels disagree**, comes from the same small experiments. Discarding the number while keeping the conclusion drawn from it would be the same citation failure wearing better clothes.

So treat it as what it is: a **practitioner's heuristic**, widely held, consistent with what experienced teachers report, and not established for classroom instruction by the evidence cited in this topic. It is worth acting on, because the cost of acting on it is low and the cost of ignoring it is a class that does not believe you. It is not worth asserting as a research finding, and you should not write it in an assignment as though it were one.

When the channels contradict

That last point is the whole of the Mr Tariq vignette. His words said safe; his folded arms, absent gaze and falling intonation said displeased. They did not believe the words. Whether that is a general law or a strong regularity is exactly what the previous section said is unestablished, but you do not need the general law to teach well here: this class, on this day, read the posture.

This has three practical consequences.

Reassurance is not a verbal act. If you intend to tell a class they are safe to be wrong, the posture, the gaze and the pause have to carry it, or the sentence is worse than useless because it also teaches that what the teacher says is unreliable.

Praise inherits the same problem. Praise delivered without looking up is heard as dismissal.

Your state leaks. A teacher who is tired, worried about something at home, or frustrated by the previous class will transmit it whatever the words. The professional response is not to pretend, which fails, but to name it briefly and truthfully where appropriate: a class told "I am short of sleep today, so tell me if

"I go too fast" is given a way to read the signals correctly instead of concluding they are the cause.

Activity: One instruction, four ways

Work in groups of three, with one observer per round.

Take a single instruction, for example: "Work in pairs and produce three examples of an improper fraction, in five minutes." Deliver it four times, changing only the non-verbal channel each time: once from behind a desk with no eye contact; once moving into the room with distributed gaze; once flat in vocal tone; once with a deliberate pause before the time limit.

The observer records, each time, what they would actually do as a pupil, and how confident they are about what was expected.

Rotate so everyone delivers and observes. Allow 25 minutes. The finding that lands hardest is usually that the words were identical every time.

Check your understanding

1. Name the four jobs verbal communication does in a classroom. (*Remember*)
2. Explain why "does everyone understand?" is a poor comprehension check and give a better alternative. (*Understand*)
3. List five non-verbal channels and state the classroom use of each. (*Remember*)
4. Mr Tariq's class did not believe him. Explain what happened, using the idea of contradicting channels. (*Apply*)
5. A trainee cites the claim that 93% of communication is non-verbal. Explain what is wrong with the claim, and explain why simply replacing it with "the non-verbal channel wins when they disagree" does not fix the underlying problem. (*Analyze*)

Summary

Verbal communication does four jobs in a classroom: explaining, instructing, questioning and responding. Teachers are typically strongest at explaining and weakest at questioning, where the difference between discovering what pupils think and confirming that someone can say the right words is the difference between a useful lesson and a comfortable one. The sentence immediately after a pupil speaks teaches the whole class whether answering is safe.

Non-verbal communication runs on identifiable channels: proximity, body orientation, gaze, facial expression, gesture and vocal variety. Learners read these as evidence about teaching quality, not merely about mood. The commonly quoted percentage claim about non-verbal communication is not supportable and should not be repeated; the defensible and more useful point is that non-verbal channels are read fast and continuously. The further claim that learners follow the non-verbal channel when the two contradict is a practitioner's heuristic worth acting on, not a finding the evidence in this topic establishes, and it descends from the same experiments the 93% claim does. The evidence cited here comes from university students, not from schoolchildren, and Furlich's non-verbal result was not significant.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can name the four jobs of verbal communication and identify which I am weakest at.
- ☐ I can replace a confidence-sampling question with one that discovers what pupils think.
- ☐ I can name the non-verbal channels and say what each is for in a classroom.
- ☐ I can say what is heuristic and what is established about channels contradicting each other.
- ☐ I can explain why the 93% claim is not usable, and why its usual replacement inherits the same weakness.

Try this at your practicum school

Ask a peer or your mentor to observe one of your lessons recording only two things: where you stood, minute by minute, and which pupils you made eye contact with.

Map the results onto a seating plan afterwards. Nearly every trainee finds a neglected zone, usually one side of the room or the back corner furthest from the door. Note who sits there and how they behaved during the lesson.

Teach the same class again with the single goal of reaching that zone, and have the observer repeat the record.

Summative task

Write 400 to 450 words.

Rewrite Mr Tariq's moment so that the class believes him, and explain why your version works.

Give the words you would use and describe the non-verbal delivery precisely: position, orientation, gaze, pace, pause. Then explain what each element is doing, and address the objection that the class's poor homework does in fact warrant displeasure and that a warmer delivery would misrepresent the situation.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Verbal content (Apply)	The words are specific and usable, not a paraphrase of "be encouraging"
Non-verbal specification	Names position, orientation, gaze, pace and pause concretely enough to be enacted
Analysis of the objection (Analyze)	Engages with the real tension between honesty about poor work and keeping the room open, rather than choosing warmth and ignoring it

Criterion	What a strong response does
Mechanism	Explains why each element works, and marks which part of the reasoning is established evidence and which is practitioner heuristic

Further reading

- Furlich, S. A. (2016). Understanding instructor nonverbal immediacy, verbal immediacy, and student motivation **at a small liberal arts university**. *Journal of the Scholarship of Teaching and Learning*, 16(3), 11-22.
<https://doi.org/10.14434/josotl.v16i3.19284> Note the setting: a small liberal arts university, per the paper's own title. The abstract states no sample size and names no country. Furlich found the verbal immediacy relationship significant and the **non-verbal one not significant**.
- Abekah Keelson, S., Odei Addo, J., & Dodor, A. (2024). The influence of lecturer non-verbal cues on student perceptions of teaching quality: **The role of gender and age**. *Cogent Education*, 11(1).
<https://doi.org/10.1080/2331186X.2024.2325788> 614 university students in Ghana, self-report.

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